



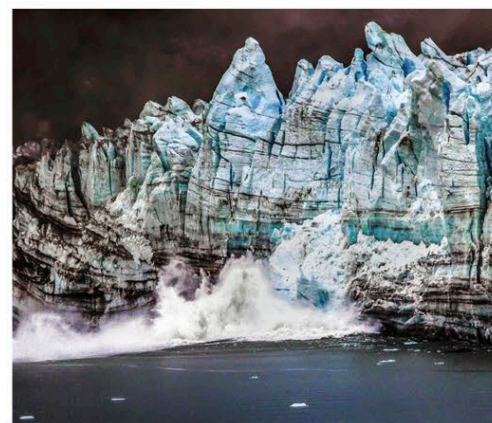
The Margerie Glacier

A glacier with a spectacular terminal wall that drops blue icebergs into Glacier Bay

The Margerie Glacier originates from the eastern end of the St. Elias Mountains, in southeastern Alaska, and discharges icebergs into Glacier Bay (an inlet of the Gulf of Alaska). Glaciers that flow down to the sea are called tidewater glaciers. The Margerie Glacier's terminal wall is in Tarr Inlet, at the northern end of the Bay, and is 260 ft (80 m) high. Unlike most other Alaskan glaciers, it has not retreated in recent years.

History of the bay

Glacier Bay was entirely filled with a single massive glacier when the English naval officer Captain George Vancouver discovered it in 1794. But due to higher temperatures and lower average snowfall over the last few centuries, this has been transformed into a 60-mile- (100-km-) long fiord with many smaller glaciers feeding ice and meltwater into it, including the Margerie.



◁ FALLING APART

A huge quantity of ice drops from the 1-mile- (1.5-km-) wide terminus of Margerie Glacier into Glacier Bay. This occurs several times each day, accompanied by thunderous cracking noises.

ICEBERG CALVING

Glaciers that flow to the coast extend only a short distance over the sea. The stress created by the glacier's weight causes chunks to break off and float away as icebergs. This is called iceberg calving.

